

Creating Unified Content Experiences

October 27–30, 2019 Portland, Oregon

Unified Content Strategy in the Real World

Sharmila Rammohan
Senior Manager, LinkedIn

Rebecca Rhee
Sr Technical Writer/Information Architect, Thermo Fisher

CONTENT AS A BUSINESS ASSET

Unified content strategy in practice

A LavaCon case study based on a product launch

Sharmila Das · Rebecca Rhee

Content strategy, information architecture, and cross-team workflow

Content has value beyond one deliverable

A trusted source can serve several formats and customer needs over time.

The pilot exposed roughly 30% overlap, creating an immediate reuse opportunity.

What makes it an asset:

1. An owner and review date
2. Approved, reusable knowledge
3. Evidence of customer use
4. The cost of upkeep and risk

Unified content strategy at a glance

One customer journey needs a shared plan across the teams behind it.

The pilot found roughly 30% overlap in the content reviewed.

This presentation covers:

1. Shared decisions across teams
2. A seven-step working method
3. A product-launch pilot
4. Lessons and a 90-day start

Fragmented teams create hidden content debt



Each team finishes its assignment, but no one sees the whole customer journey.

What teams agree on

01

Purpose

Start with the same customer need and desired result.

02

Source

Use one approved explanation, claim, or procedure.

03

Ownership

Agree on who creates, reviews, and maintains it.

04

Delivery

Adapt the source for each audience and channel.

Teams can keep the tools and formats that fit their work while coordinating the decisions that affect everyone.

Seven steps that worked for us

1. Analyze the business
2. Inventory content
3. Research audiences
4. Assess content quality
5. Measure performance
6. Build the roadmap
7. Publish, track, improve

Begin with the business and customer problem. Choose tools only after the team understands the work.

Business context

Content priorities should reflect how the organization creates value and where customers struggle.

Internal context

- products and services
- revenue and cost pressures
- strategic priorities
- operating constraints

External context

- customer expectations
- competitive alternatives
- market and regulatory shifts
- channel behavior

A usable content inventory

Collect enough detail to make decisions and stop when the patterns are clear.

Capture

- URL or asset location
- owner and audience
- format, channel, and lifecycle state
- performance data when available

Use it to find

- duplication and contradiction
- gaps in the customer journey
- orphaned or outdated content
- high-value reuse candidates

Audience needs and journeys

A persona becomes useful when it changes a content decision.

Understand

- role and responsibility
- task or decision
- questions and barriers
- preferred access point

Connect to journey

- discover and evaluate
- purchase and onboard
- use and troubleshoot
- adopt and advocate

Content quality and reuse

A polished asset can still be inaccurate, hard to find, or difficult to reuse.

Quality review

- accuracy and currency
- clarity and organization
- findability and metadata
- accessibility and usability

Reuse review

- source ownership
- content granularity
- format dependence
- rights and lifecycle constraints

Customer use and team effort

Pair customer data with production data so the team can see what helps and what slows the work.

Customer signals

- views, search, and completion
- downloads and engagement
- support deflection
- task success and feedback

Team signals

- cycle time and rework
- review effort
- duplicate production
- reuse across teams and channels

The roadmap

The roadmap connects audience needs with topics, sources, channels, owners, and timing.

Roadmap fields

- topic and purpose
- journey stage
- source and format
- channel and owner

Decision criteria

- customer value
- reuse potential
- risk and dependency
- effort and sequencing

Launch and follow-up

The team begins learning once customers can use the content.

At launch

- confirm ownership
- validate links and metadata
- connect analytics
- document source and version

After launch

- review performance
- retire or revise weak content
- capture feedback
- feed learning into the next cycle

We tested the approach on a product launch

The setting

A complex product environment where technical publications, training, rich media, marketing, service, and field teams created content independently.

Pilot objectives

- find overlap in content and effort
- agree on requirements for a new product
- assign work by expertise
- test a process that later launches could use

The audit exposed a 30% reuse opportunity

30%

of reviewed content overlapped across teams

The team compared source material, finished content, and planned deliverables across functions.

- Teams found material they could reuse right away.
- Missing content surfaced earlier in the lifecycle.
- The audit gave teams a practical way to divide the work.
- The same method could be used on later launches.

The audit moved the discussion from document ownership to responsibility for the source information.

The stakeholder map showed who had to be involved

Business direction

- Product management
- Product marketing
- Subject-matter experts

Content creation

- Technical publications
- Customer education
- Instructional design

Experience delivery

- Customer support
- Field service
- Sales enablement

Platform and assets

- IT and CMS
- CAD and mechanical
- Rich media

A simple process replaced informal handoffs

1

Align

Common kickoff and agreed requirements

2

Source

Identify source materials and owners

3

Create

Assign work by expertise and reuse potential

4

Review

Coordinate review across affected teams

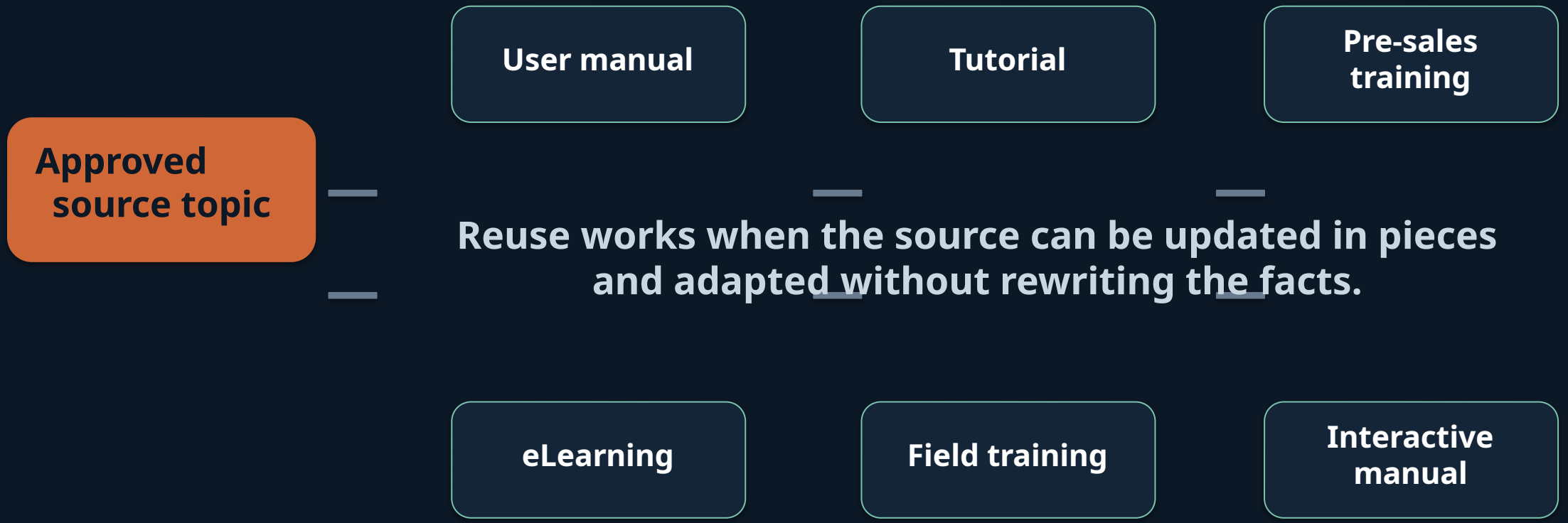
5

Learn

Track results and improve the next release

Weekly meetings kept dependencies visible. Executive sponsors settled ownership and tool decisions when the teams reached an impasse.

One approved topic can support many formats



What changed after the pilot

01

Clarity

Teams could see overlap, gaps, and dependencies.

02

Capacity

Work moved to the teams best equipped to create and maintain it.

03

Repeatability

The audit and planning method could be used on later launches.

04

Platform case

The findings supported a broader CMS and collaboration initiative.

The pilot gave teams a repeatable way to make decisions together.

Four lessons from the pilot

Ownership affects adoption

People respond to changes in tools, control, and recognition.

Make the process easy to enter

Occasional contributors need clear templates and support.

Sponsors remove roadblocks

Some cross-team decisions need a leader to settle them.

Use the same measures

Customer results and team effort help resolve format debates.

A 90-day starting plan

Days 1–30

Choose one difficult customer journey. Map the teams, content, owners, and measures.

Days 31–60

Run a cross-functional audit. Identify reuse, gaps, and ownership.

Days 61–90

Test the requirements and workflow. Measure cycle time, rework, and reuse.

Start where coordination pain and customer value are both visible.

Start with one customer journey. Find the overlap and agree on ownership.

Test the process with a small group. Track repeated work, review time, reuse, and customer results.

Questions